MODULE 00 · EXAM STRATEGY - ALL DOMAINS

AWS Certified Developer – Associate

DVA-C02. Eleven hours, all four domains at their published weights, 184 worked scenarios.

EXAM **DVA-C02** MODULES **35** SCENARIOS **184**

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Almost nobody fails this exam because a service is unfamiliar. They fail because all four options would work, and one clause decides.

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The exam

	VALUE
Questions	65 total. 50 scored, 15 unscored and not identified
Time	130 minutes. Exactly 2 minutes per question
Pass mark	720 of 1,000, scaled. Not a percentage
Scoring	Compensatory. No per-domain pass mark
Question types	Multiple choice, and multiple response with no partial credit
Guessing	No penalty. Never leave a question blank
Cost and validity	150 USD. Valid 3 years. 14-day wait to retake

READ THIS TWICE

If English is not your first language, request the ESL plus 30 minutes accommodation in your AWS Certification account BEFORE you schedule. Most who qualify never ask.

The four domains

DOMAIN	WEIGHT AND WHAT IT ASKS
1. Development with AWS Services	32%. Can you build it with the right services?
2. Security	26%. Can you make it reachable only by who should reach it?
3. Deployment	24%. Can you ship it repeatedly and safely?
4. Troubleshooting and Optimization	18%. Can you tell what is wrong when it breaks?

ON THE EXAM

The course matches these weights deliberately: 12 modules on Domain 1, 5 on Domain 2, 5 on Domain 3, 4 on Domain 4.

How the course is arranged

MODULES	WHAT THEY COVER
01 to 02	Foundations: the mental model, and how an SDK call actually works
03 to 14	Domain 1. Lambda, DynamoDB, S3, API Gateway, messaging, containers
15 to 19	Domain 2. IAM, roles, Cognito, KMS, secrets
20 to 24	Domain 3. CloudFormation, SAM and CDK, CI/CD, CodeDeploy, versions
25 to 28	Domain 4. CloudWatch, X-Ray, troubleshooting, cost
29 to 31	Synthesis. Confusion pairs, how questions are written, the revision gap
32 to 34	Three practice exams. 60 questions, no repeats

ON THE EXAM

Watch in order. Later modules assume vocabulary earlier ones established, and the synthesis modules draw on everything before them.

What is in each module

- A **core idea** stated first, so you know what the module is really about.
- Teaching slides, with the examinable facts marked and the limits stated precisely.
- A **tiebreaker** slide wherever two services or features are easily confused.
- **Worked scenarios** at the end, in the shape the exam uses.
- A recap naming the five things to carry forward.

> ON THE EXAM
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> There are 50 tiebreaker slides across the course. Those are the pairs the exam deliberately puts side by side, and module 29 gathers them.

The scenario convention

- **184 worked scenarios:** 124 in the teaching modules, 60 across three practice exams.
- **Pause and commit to an answer** before the walkthrough. A guess you did not commit to teaches nothing.
- Every walkthrough explains **all four options**, not only the correct one.
- Each ends with **The signal**: the exact clause that decided the answer.
- Several include a deliberate **near miss**: correct engineering, wrong for the scenario.

> READ THIS TWICE
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> Understanding why a distractor fails is what transfers to an unseen question. Memorising a correct answer does not.

What changed under this exam

- Exam guide **v2.1** was published on 12 December 2024. AWS has not stopped shipping since.
- This course flags **22 specific changes** at the point where each one is taught.
- Each note states the **examinable answer first**, then what is true now, with a date.
- Some answers the exam still marks correct describe things you can no longer buy.
- **Module 31** gathers all of them into one timeline.

> ON THE EXAM
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> S3 Select has been closed to new customers since July 2024 and remains a correct exam answer. That gap is why the notes exist.

How to work through it

- **1.** Watch modules 01 to 31 in order. Pause and commit at every scenario.
- **2.** Take practice exam 1 and score it **by domain**, not just overall.
- **3.** Review every wrong answer until you can say why all four options are right or wrong.
- **4.** Take exam 2. Leave several days before exam 3.
- **5.** Rewatch **Confusion Pairs** and **The Revision Gap** the night before you sit.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Recall after a gap predicts a pass far better than recall immediately after watching. The days between exams 2 and 3 are doing real work.

Reading your practice scores

- **17 or more out of 20, consistently:** you are ready to book.
- **14 to 16:** passing territory, with a domain or two to firm up.
- **Below 14:** average your domain scores and revisit the weakest two modules.
- A domain weak in **all three** exams is a real gap. Weak in one is sampling noise.
- Any answer you got right but could not justify is a guess, not knowledge.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Twenty questions is a small sample. Comparing the three exams by domain tells you far more than any single total.

Who this is for

- AWS describes the candidate as having **one or more years** of development on AWS.
- You should be comfortable in **at least one programming language**. Snippets are mostly Python.
- No prior AWS certification is required, and none is assumed here.
- You do not need to have used every service. Each is introduced before it is tested.
- If you are coming from servers rather than serverless, **module 01 matters most**.

> ON THE EXAM
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> The most common background gap is not technical. It is the habit of thinking in machines rather than services, which module 01 addresses directly.

What this exam does not ask

- It does not ask you to **write code**. You read snippets and say what they do.
- It does not ask for **pricing figures**, only relative cost.
- It does not test **console click paths** or CLI flags.
- It does not go deep on **networking**. VPCs appear as constraints, not as subjects.
- It does expect **limits, defaults and which service fits**, repeatedly.

> ON THE EXAM
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> People routinely over-prepare on networking and under-prepare on limits. Roughly thirty numbers decide a meaningful share of the questions.

Before you sit

- Check the **in-scope service list** in the current exam guide before you book.
- Request the **ESL accommodation** before scheduling if it applies to you.
- Decide on **testing centre or online proctored** early. Online has room requirements.
- Two minutes per question. Flag at two and a half and move on.
- **Never leave a question blank.** There is no penalty for a wrong answer.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Module 30 covers exam technique in full: reading order, the qualifier words, and the six kinds of wrong answer.

Every scenario in this course is original.
None of it is a reproduced question bank.